in Bengal had shown it was possible. Was Modi, then, sui generis? Was there something in the saffron-hued Ahmedabad air that evening which suggested this was a watershed moment in Indian politics?

Later that night, as the dust settled and the television talking heads made their exit, I telephoned Mr Modi's residence in Gandhinagar to congratulate him. A little after midnight, he returned the call. 'Congratulations on your victory,' I said. His response was in Hindi. *'Dhanyawaad, bhaiya!'* I asked him whether his decision to deliver a victory speech in Hindi was the clearest sign yet that he wanted to make a pitch for prime minister. *'Rajdeep, jab aap reporter editor ban sakte ho, toh kya chief minister, pradhan mantri nahi ban sakte kya?'* (If a reporter like you can become an editor, why can't a chief minister become a prime minister.) Stated with his trademark gift of quick-witted repartee, there was my answer.

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The first time I met Narendra Damodardas Modi, I was a young reporter with the *Times of India* in Mumbai. The year was 1990 and I had been in the profession for less than two years. My hair had not greyed nor had Modi's. He was wearing a loose, well-starched kurta–pyjama and greeted us warmly. Almost instantly, he became Narendrabhai for all the journalists.

The occasion was the Ram rath yatra of L.K. Advani from Somnath to Ayodhya. I had been assigned to cover one leg of the yatra as it wound its way from Gujarat into Maharashtra. Actually, I was the secondary reporter, tasked with looking for some 'colour' stories around the main event. I joined the yatra in Surat as it moved across south Gujarat and then into Maharashtra. For me, it was a big opportunity to gain a ringside view of a major national political event, away from the local Mumbai politics beat.

It was a big occasion for Narendra Modi too. He was then the BJP's organizing secretary in Gujarat, the RSS's point person for the state, looking to carve an identity for himself well beyond being just another pracharak. If the rath yatra provided me an opportunity for a front-page byline, it gave Modi a chance to take a step up the political ladder. His role